



Inca empire, and many of their customs and rituals are rooted in this ancient and powerful culture. Later, they were heavily influenced by the Spanish colonists, who exploited their traditional craft and weaving skills, taught

them new ones, and provided access to extensive markets in other parts of the world. Today, the Otavalen people are among the most prosperous indigenous groups in the whole of South America.

Saturday shopping

There are two main markets in Otavalo—one that supplies food, animals, and household goods to the local people, and one that sells textiles and crafts to the tourists. Saturday is market day, and many of the stalls are open for business before dawn. By midmorning, the local market is closing down, and by noon, even the tourists have drifted away.



PIG FOR THE POT

Otavalen shoppers take special care when it comes to choosing one of their most important purchases—live guinea pigs, known as *cuy*s. These animals, which slightly resemble large rabbits with small ears, are kept almost like pets until a special occasion arises. Then they are killed and cooked for the celebration feast.



WORKING TRADITION

Both clothing and domestic textiles play an important part in Otavalo craft heritage. Here, a busy tailor makes practical use of a mechanized sewing machine at his market stall. Behind him hangs a selection of colorful rugs woven from the wool of llamas and alpacas. Both these Andean creatures are distant relatives of the camel.



This flower seller, like many other traders, travels a long way to buy and sell goods at Otavalo market.



HATS ON

Like many people exposed to long periods of bright sunlight, the Otavalens usually wear hats, and making them is part of their craft tradition. Two of the most popular styles are the pale woven Panama (all *genuine* Panama hats are made in Ecuador), and the *sombrero*, which is molded under pressure out of damp woolen felt.